

White House, immigration remains one of America's deepest fault lines, while relations between the United States and Mexico continue to oscillate between cooperation and confrontation. Canada, too, is navigating a more complicated relationship with its giant neighbour. Yet, for 39 days, the three nations will attempt to stage the biggest sporting event the world has ever seen.

Iran, locked in a geopolitical confrontation with the United States and its ally Israel, could be playing its World Cup matches in America while based across the border in Mexico, as authorities explore ways to avoid extended stays by the Iranian delegation on U.S. soil.

Football, forever sold as a force for unity,

finds itself increasingly tethered to power under Gianni Infantino, whose stewardship of FIFA has often resembled that of a luxury hotel concierge: always near influence, always smiling and always ensuring the most important people in the room feel celebrated. That instinct has been glaringly visible in his relationship with President Trump, a courtship that appears to have washed away the last remnants of FIFA's neutrality. The governing body created a new FIFA Peace Prize in 2025

Enduring legacy: Lionel Messi will play in a sixth World Cup as he captains holders Argentina at the 2026 tournament.REUTERS

